

Micro-Phenomenological Interview – Imaginative Suggestions

The following interview script is to be used to investigate participants' internal experience of responding (or not) to imaginative suggestions, using the micro-phenomenological interview (or micro-analytic interview) approach (Stern, 2004; Petitmengin, 2006; Valenzuela-Moguillansky & Vásquez-Rosati, 2019). This script should be deployed after each suggestion has been concluded, and it should continue until both the experimenter and the participant are satisfied that all descriptions and nuances have been expressed for the suggestion under consideration. The sessions should be video recorded in order to facilitate analysis.

To allow the participants as much free reign as possible in answering the questions, the script is presented as more of a flow chart than a straight forward script. It will be the interviewer's responsibility to identify the most appropriate path through the flow chart, based on the answers given and how and where they feel more detail could be discovered.

The following script will consider, for example, an imaginative suggestion for hands coming together. For all other suggestions, the wording should be modified accordingly. If a participant fails to provide a satisfactory account of the thoughts and feelings that they were aware of during a suggestion, then the suggestion should be repeated except with the participant verbalising all the thoughts and feelings that they are aware of *as they experience them*. It is felt that this switch from *retrospective remembering* to *expression in the moment* will help those participants report their inner experiences more accurately and with greater verbosity.

Suggestions to be Presented

The process will start with a 'warm up' exercise that can be used to introduce the process to the participant. During the recounting of this exercise, the experimenter may provide overt prompts and ask leading questions to encourage the participant to engage more fully with the process. The results of this exercise will not be included in the analysis. This will be followed by the PCS introduction, and then each imaginative exercise. Participants will be asked to close their eyes for the duration of each exercise, and then to open them again for the interviews about them.

The suggestions to be presented (taken verbatim from the Phenomenological Control Scale [PCS, Lush et al, 2021] or modified from existing PCS scale items) are as follows:

Moving Hands Together Warm Up Exercise (adapted from PCS)

Please extend your arms ahead of you, with palms facing each other, hands about a foot apart. Hold your hands about a foot apart, palms facing each other. Please close your eyes for the duration of this exercise. I want you to move your hands together so that they take about five seconds before they touch. Simply move your hands towards each other so that after about five seconds, they touch. Do that now.

Allow 5 seconds.

That's fine. Please open your eyes.

Follow the interview script.

Preliminary Instructions (adapted from PCS)

You will shortly be given some exercises in the use of your imagination to create certain experiences. The aim is to see how much you can control the way you experience some simple events, such as moving your hands. For example, first you will be asked to move your hands together, and imagine they are being pulled together by themselves. Engage yourself in that imagination, until it really feels like they are being pulled together by themselves. Focus on the sensations and on the imaginary situation so you can immerse yourself in that reality, as if, for example, you were getting carried away by the narrative of a film, as if it were real. Afterwards, I will ask you to rate how strong you felt each experience; for example, how much the arms seemed to move by themselves. I will then ask you to describe in detail all the thoughts and feelings you were aware of during each exercise. Your results on these exercises depend upon your willingness to try to imagine and to visualize the things I will ask you to imagine. What I ask is your cooperation in helping this experiment by trying to imagine vividly what I describe to you.

Moving Hands Together (taken verbatim from PCS)

Now extend your arms ahead of you, with palms facing each other, hands about a foot apart. Hold your hands about a foot apart, palms facing each other. I want you to think about a force acting on your hands to pull them together, as though one hand were attracting the other. You are thinking of your hands being pulled together, and they begin to move together... coming together... coming together... moving together... closer together... more and more towards each other... more and more...

Allow 5 seconds.

That's fine. You notice how closely thought and movement are related. Now place your hands back in their resting position.

Hands Stuck Together (adapted from PCS arm immobilisation suggestion)

Now extend your arms ahead of you, as before, but with the palms pressed together. I want you now to think about your hands. Pay close attention to them. They are beginning to stick together ... Notice that sensation as your hands begin to stick ... Your hands are beginning to stick together ... Tighter and tighter ... More and more stuck. You might like to find out a little later how sticky your hands are ... they seem too stuck to separate them ... but in spite of how stuck they are, maybe you can move them a little; but maybe they are too stuck for that ... Why don't you see how stuck they are ... Just try to separate your hands, just try.

Allow 5 seconds.

That's fine. Now place your hands back in their resting positions. Your hands and arms now feel normal again. They are no longer sticky or stuck.

Music Hallucination (taken verbatim from PCS)

In a few moments, a recording of 'Happy Birthday to You' will be played for you. When the recording starts the volume will be turned way down and you will probably not be able to hear it, or you will hear it very faintly. Then the volume will increase and I want you to indicate when you can hear it satisfactorily by holding up your right hand. When you can hear the music satisfactorily, hold

up your right hand. Okay? Here we go ... The recording of 'Happy Birthday to You' has been turned on. This is Level One.

Allow 5 seconds.

Now it is being turned up a little. This is Level Two. Hold your hand up if you can hear it now.

Allow 5 seconds.

And now louder. This is Level Three.

Allow 5 seconds.

And now the loudest setting. This is Level Four. Hold your hand up if you can hear the music now.

Allow 5 seconds.

Now the music has been turned off. There now, there is no longer any music. You can return your hand to its resting position. Now ... just sit back.

Interview Script

(To be presented after each exercise has concluded.)

Now we are going to (again) examine those few seconds in as much detail as possible to understand all the things you were thinking, feeling and imagining during that process. (Again) We're interested in as much detail as you can provide; what we'd like is the most accurate record that you can achieve. Please only concern yourself with what you thought, felt and imagined during the experience. Please answer as honestly and truthfully as you can. We have no expectations at all of how we think people might answer. What we really want are the actual facts of what happened so that we can design better experiments in the future.

To start with, please could you tell me about your initial thoughts when I gave you the exercise? What were the first thoughts that went through your mind before anything actually happened?

(Ask the participant to elaborate on any thoughts or imaginings they describe. Explore interpretational thoughts [about what the suggestion was asking for], contextual thoughts [how did

they feel about being asked to do this?], and any spontaneous imagination [did they imagine what might happen?]. e.g. "Can you tell me more about ...")

While I was giving you the exercise, what was going through your mind? What were you thinking or imagining?

If something. Please can you describe that in as much detail as you can? (Encourage as much detail and as many different thoughts/imaginings as they would like to talk about. If they only mention thoughts, ask about imaginings; ditto, if they only mention imaginings, ask about thoughts.)

If nothing. Please think back to that moment. Are you aware of anything going on in your head at the time?

If still nothing. Some people are aware of the positions of their hands; others might be aware of feelings or images in their mind. Were you aware of any of these types of things?

What did you think about your response to the suggestion? Did it surprise you?

References

- Lush, P., Scott, R. B., Seth, A., & Dienes, Z. (2021). The Phenomenological Control Scale: Measuring the capacity for creating illusory nonvolition, hallucination and delusion. *Collabra: Psychology*, 7(1): 29542.
- Petitmengin, C. (2006). Describing one's subjective experience in the second person: An interview method for the science of consciousness. *Phenomenology and the Cognitive sciences*, 5(3-4), 229-269.
- Stern, D. N. (2004). *The present moment in psychotherapy and everyday life (Norton series on interpersonal neurobiology)*. WW Norton & Company.
- Valenzuela-Moguillansky, C., & Vásquez-Rosati, A. (2019). An analysis procedure for the micro-phenomenological interview. *Constructivist Foundations*, 14(2), 123-145.